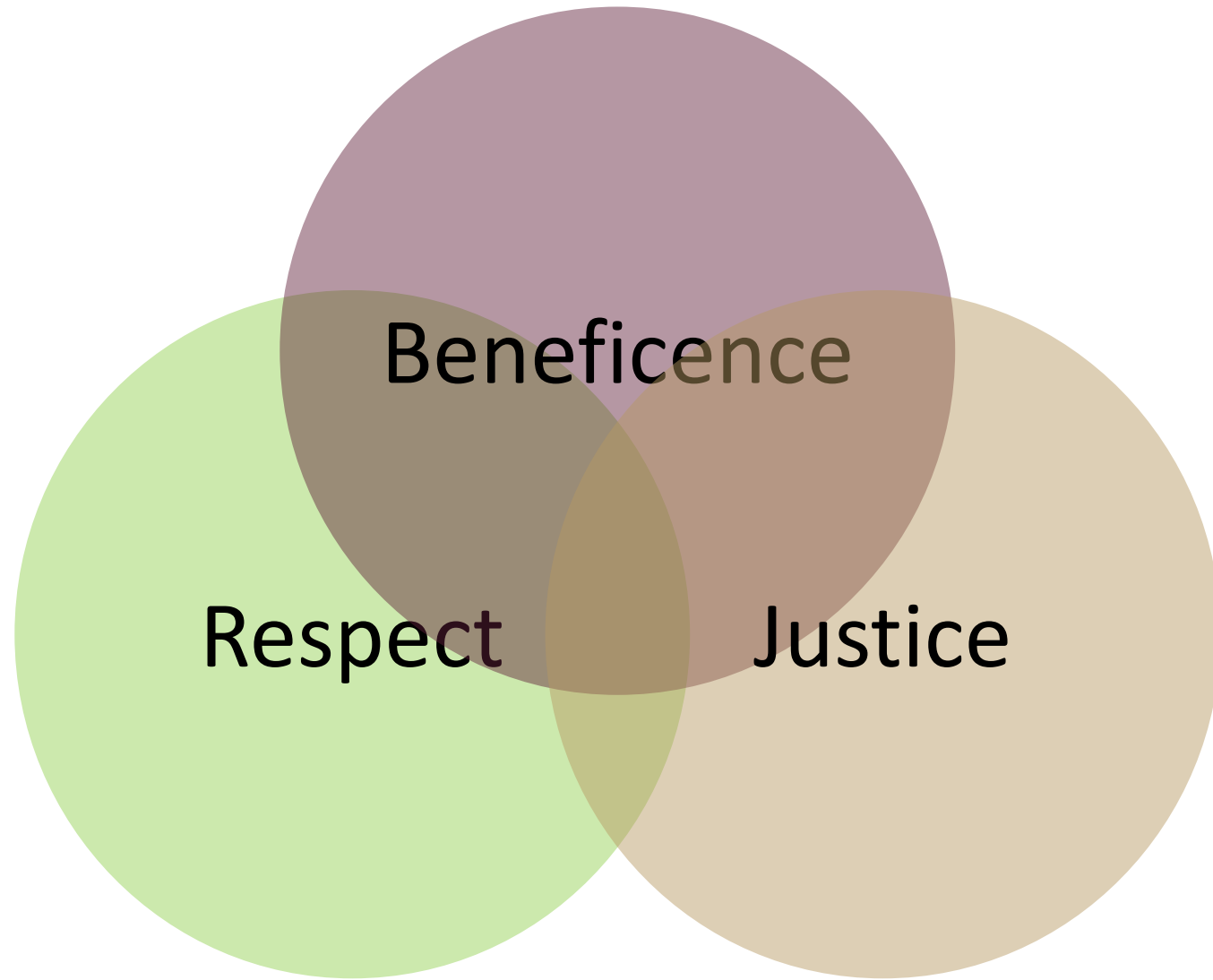


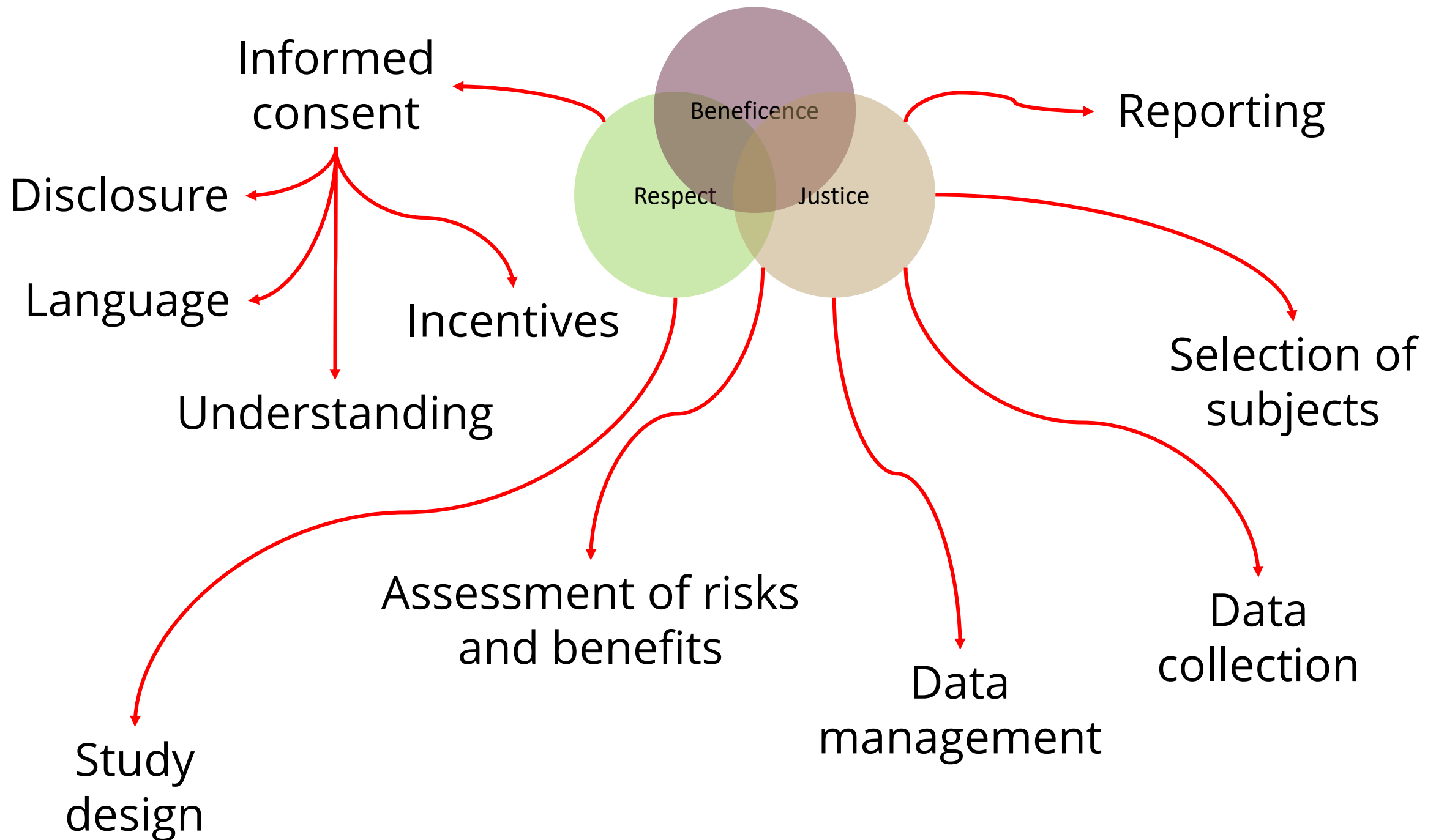


Survey Methods

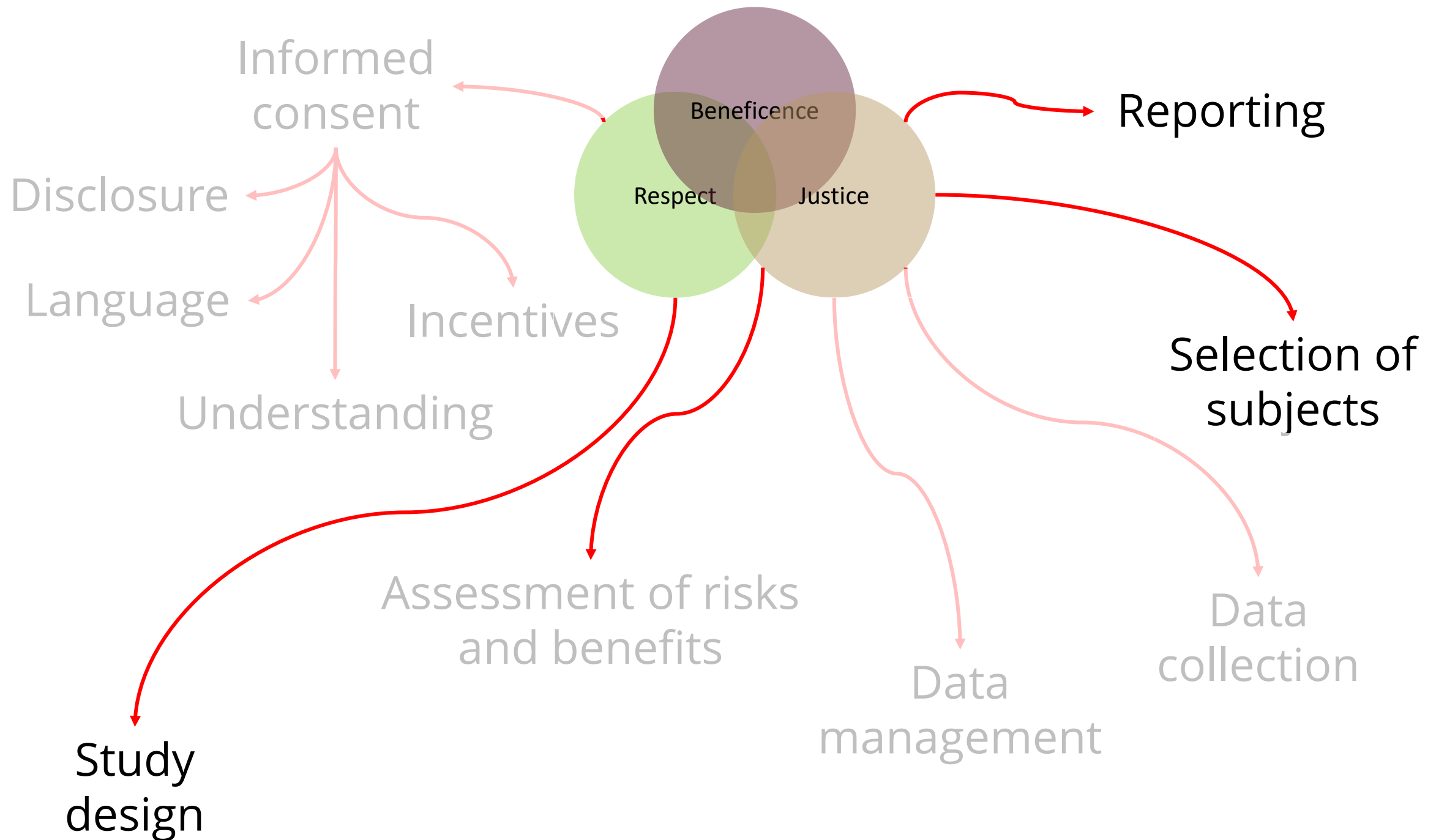
5.2 - Ethical Aspects in Survey Research

- Ethics in survey research









Ethical reviews

The screenshot shows the website for the Health Research Ethics Office at Stellenbosch University. The header includes the university's name in English and Afrikaans, along with navigation links for 'About us', 'Doctoral Office', 'Research Grants Management', 'Undergraduate Research', 'Registrar Research', and 'COVID-19 Latest updates'. A search bar and a language selector for 'AFRIKAANS' are also present. The main content area is titled 'Research Development and Health Research Ethics' and 'About the Health Research Ethics'. A central text box states: 'We strive to create a service friendly environment where researchers can access support and guidance for all ethical and regulatory aspects of health research. Contact our office to book a consult where you will be provided with one-on-one guidance on getting your research protocol to meet local and international ethics standards.' Below this, there are three buttons: 'Health Research Ethics Committees (HRECs): Ethics Review', 'Consult Service', and 'Capacity'. On the right side, there are two important announcements: 'IMPORTANT ANNOUNCEMENTS' with a link to 'updates from the Health Research Ethics Office (HREO)', and 'Kindly click here for the LATEST COVID-19 UPDATES'. The footer includes a link to 'Health Research Ethics HOME'.

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Consult Service

We strive to create a service friendly environment where researchers can access support and guidance for all ethical and regulatory aspects of health research. Contact our office to book a consult where you will be provided with one-on-one guidance on getting your research protocol to meet local and international ethics standards.

Research Development and Health Research Ethics

About the Health Research Ethics

The primary purpose of the Health Research Ethics Office is towards compliance in the protection of human participants.

Functions of this office include the administration of Stellenbosch University Research Ethics Committees; providing general guidance on meeting local and international requirements; and building institutional health research ethics capacity.

Health Research Ethics Committees (HRECs): Ethics Review

Consult Service

Capacity

IMPORTANT ANNOUNCEMENTS

Kindly click here for urgent updates from the Health Research Ethics Office (HREO)

Kindly click here for the LATEST COVID-19 UPDATES

Health Research Ethics HOME

Summary questions

- Which aspect of the process of designing and conduction a survey have relevant ethical implications

References

Oldendick, Robert W. 2012. 'Survey Research Ethics'. In *Handbook of Survey Methodology for the Social Sciences*, 23–35. Springer.

Other resources

Groves, Robert M, Floyd J Fowler Jr, Mick P Couper, James M Lepkowski, Eleanor Singer, and Roger Tourangeau. 2009. *Survey Methodology*. John Wiley & Sons – Chapter 11

Recruiting respondents

- **Representation:** Are your survey respondents representative?
- **Correct Sample:** Are you surveying the wrong people? If you're recruiting through a clinic or a school, but you're interested in underserved populations, you might be missing people.
- **Trust Building:** If your survey is sensitive in nature, how will you gain trust? If answering your questions could trigger painful memories, will you provide a number to call such as a domestic violence hotline, or HIV hotline?

Designing the data collection tool

- **Specificity:** “Do you like fried chicken?” is not the same as “Do you like KFC?” Personally, I love to eat fried chicken from a local BBQ restaurant by my apartment, but I actually do not like KFC. If you ask me, “Do you like fried chicken” and I respond “yes,” it would be false to conclude that I like KFC.
- **Loaded Meanings:** Generational, gender, and cultural differences all factor in to how people interpret and respond to survey questions.
- **Regional Assumptions/Biases:** Geographical/regional differences can play into different interpretations of questions. A question such as “What do you like to do on snow days?” won’t make much sense to people in warmer areas who haven’t experienced snow days.

Designing the data collection tool

- **Question order:** Priming is when current actions are influenced by very recent information. For example, if a school is interviewing a group of parents and places a question such as “What is the most pressing issue facing our school today?” right before “How well do you think our school principal is doing?,” respondents will be primed to think of the principal’s response to the issue they just chose right before. Early items in your survey could have an effect on later responses.
- **Testing and Translation:** Ensuring consistency across languages; do not exclude respondents because of language...

Presenting results & protecting privacy

- **Privacy and confidentiality:** Privacy protection goes beyond ‘not collecting names, addresses or ID numbers...’. Even if someone’s name or address is not available, individuals might be able to be identified if they have unique responses to the survey, especially when responses to multiple survey questions are combined. For example, a certain neighbourhood might only have one same-sex couple household with a child, or only one 25-year-old female who is divorced.
- **Linking data across surveys** is not always ethically acceptable.



Thank you

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